

SPI

Serial Peripheral Interface

Core Concept

SPI = Serial Peripheral Interface

Also known as: **4-wire serial bus**, **SSI** (Synchronous Serial Interface)

Real analogy: Like a high-speed assembly line where the boss (master) directly talks to each worker (slave) through dedicated connections!

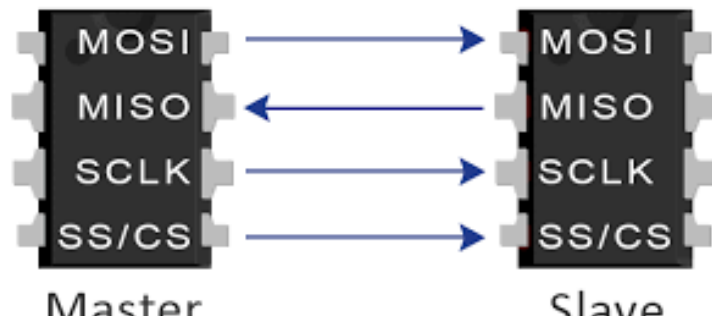
Why SPI?

A **high-speed** communication protocol for:

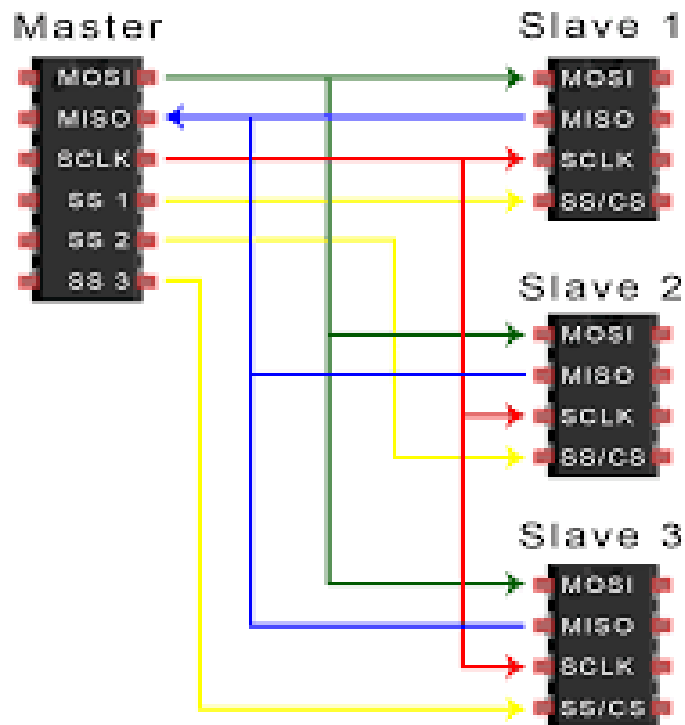
- **Fast data transfer** (up to 60+ MHz)
- **Full-duplex** communication (send & receive simultaneously)
- **Short-distance** connections (< 1 meter typically)
- **Simple protocol**: No addressing, no ACK/NACK
- **No pull-up resistors** needed

The Four Signals

- **MOSI** (Master Out Slave In): Data from master to slave
- **MISO** (Master In Slave Out): Data from slave to master
- **SCK** (Serial Clock): Clock signal from master
- **SS/CS** (Slave Select/Chip Select): Selects which slave is active



All MOSIs are connected together, all MISOs are connected together, and the master controls which slave is active with separate SS lines.



Trade-offs:

- More wires (4+ vs 2)
- More pins used
- Each slave needs its own SS/CS line

Use cases:

- SD cards (high-speed storage)
- TFT displays (lots of pixel data)
- Fast ADC/DAC converters
- RF modules (NRF24L01)
- Flash memory chips

Master-Slave Architecture

Master (usually a microcontroller):

- Generates clock (SCK)
- Initiates all communication
- Controls which slave is active (via SS lines)
- Can only be **ONE master** in basic SPI

Slave (peripherals):

- Responds when selected (SS goes LOW)
- Receives clock from master
- Cannot initiate communication
- Can be **multiple slaves** on same bus

Chip Select (SS/CS) is active LOW:

SS = LOW → Slave is selected and listening

SS = HIGH → Slave is deselected and ignoring bus

Pin Naming Variations

Warning: Different manufacturers use different names!

Signal	Common Names	Arduino Uno Pin
Master → Slave	MOSI, SDO, DO, DOUT, SO, MTSR	11 (MOSI)
Slave → Master	MISO, SDI, DI, DIN, SI, MRST	12 (MISO)
Clock	SCK, SCLK, CLK	13 (SCK)
Chip Select	SS, CS, CE, NSS	10 (SS)

Modern naming (less confusing):

- **COPI/PICO** (Controller Out Peripheral In) ← replaces MOSI
- **CIPO/POCI** (Controller In Peripheral Out) ← replaces MISO

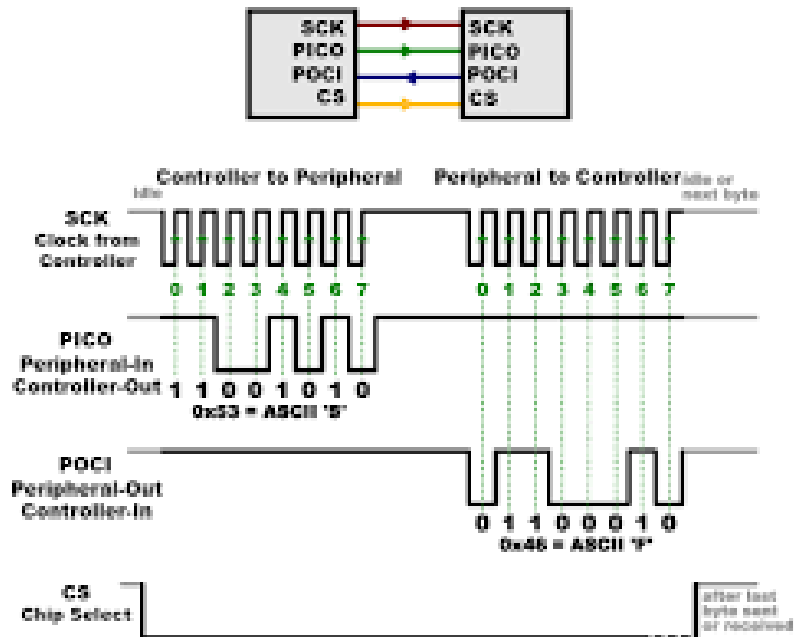
Example confusion:

NRF24L01 module:

MOSI → connected to → Arduino MOSI ✓

SDI → connected to → Arduino MOSI ✓ (same signal, different name!)

Full-Duplex Communication



Key difference from I2C: Data flows BOTH directions simultaneously!

Clock →	1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8	
MOSI →	1	0	1	0	0	1	0	1	(0xA5)
MISO ←	0	0	1	1	1	1	1	1	(0x3F)

Important: Every SPI transfer is an **exchange**:

- Master sends 8 bits → Slave receives 8 bits
- Slave sends 8 bits → Master receives 8 bits
- **Happens at the same time!**

Step-by-Step Example: Master sends 0xC7, Slave responds with 0x3A

Step 1: Master pulls SS LOW (selects slave)

Step 2: Master starts clock and shifts out data

MSB first: 1 1 0 0 0 1 1 1 = 0xC7

Step 3: Slave shifts out its response (simultaneously)

MSB first: 0 0 1 1 1 0 1 0 = 0x3A

Step 4: After 8 clock pulses, transfer complete

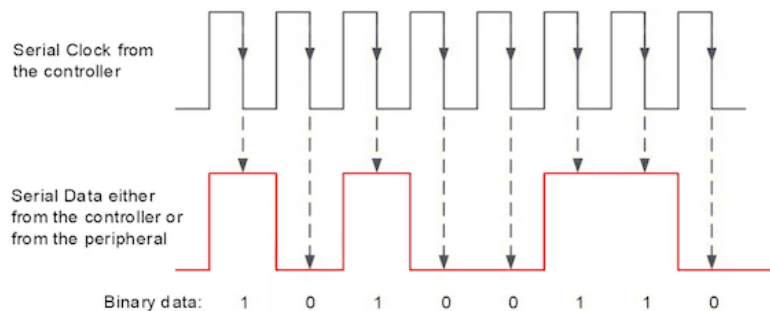
Master received: 0x3A

Slave received: 0xC7

Step 5: Master pulls SS HIGH (deselects slave)

SPI Problem

SPI is fast so it is important to transfer data correctly.



- Data should be ready and stable when it is read.
- In this example, the data is read at the falling edge, so the data should be ready at the rising edge of the clock.

Different hardware design

However, it is not easy to guarantee this timing, because different devices have different internal designs and timing requirements.

- Sensor A might make ready the signal at the rising edge, while Sensor B might make it ready at the falling edge.
- If the master reads at the wrong edge, it might read invalid data (e.g., 0x00 or 0xFF) instead of the correct value.

SPI Modes

To solve this problem, SPI defines 4 modes based on:

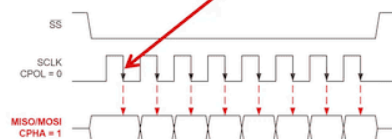
- **Clock Polarity (CPOL):** Idle state of the clock (0 = LOW, 1 = HIGH)
- **Clock Phase (CPHA):** When data is sampled (0 = first edge, 1 = second edge)

SPI Mode Numbers

SPI Mode	CPOL	CPHA
0	0	0
1	0	1
2	1	0
3	1	1

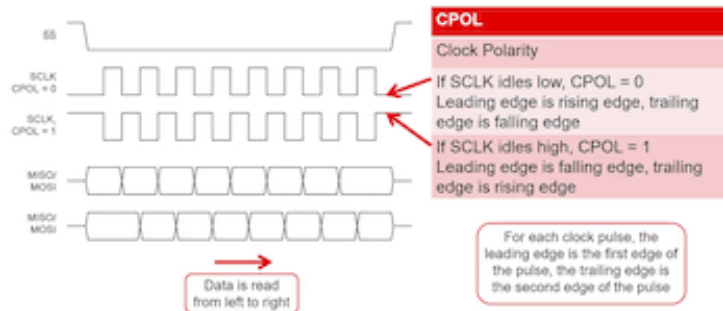
Example:

SPI Mode 1 – SCLK idles low, data is read on the trailing edge of the clock



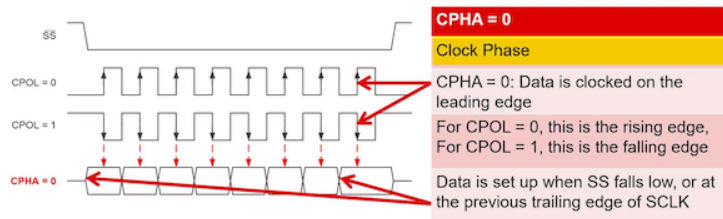
CPOL

SPI Clock Polarity: CPOL

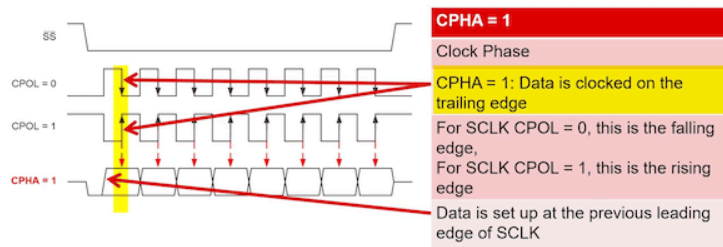


CPHA

SPI Clock Phase, CPHA = 0



SPI Clock Phase, CPHA = 1



Different Modes for Different Devices

Device	SPI Mode
SD Card	Mode 0
OLED Display	Mode 0
MCP3008 ADC	Mode 0
Some RF Chips	Mode 3
DACs (various)	Mode 1/2

The Master must be configured to match the slave's SPI mode for correct communication!

SPI: How a Slave Sends Data to a Master

Key idea:

The **slave can send data**, but the **master must start the clock**.

1) The Big Rule

In SPI, the **master controls**:

- **SCK (Clock)**
- **SS/CS (Select)**
- **When a transfer starts**

So the slave **cannot** "talk whenever it wants."

2) Full-Duplex = Two Lanes at Once

Every clock tick moves data in **both** directions:

SCK: ↑ ↑ ↑ ↑ ↑ ↑ ↑ ↑

MOSI: Master → Slave (outgoing)

MISO: Slave → Master (incoming)

Even if the master sends “nothing useful,” the clock still lets the slave send.

3) The Trick: "Dummy Write" to Read

SPI has no separate "read line."

To read, the master must **write something** to generate clock pulses.

Example idea:

- Master sends 0x00 (dummy)
- Slave uses those clocks to shift real data out on MISO

4) Byte Example (Concept)

Clocks: 1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8

MOSI : 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 0 (dummy)

MISO : D7 D6 D5 D4 D3 D2 D1 D0 (real data)

Master is "asking" by providing clocks.

5) Typical Pattern: Command → Response

Many SPI devices work like this:

1. Master selects the device (CS LOW)
2. Master sends a command (e.g., "read register 0x10")
3. Master sends dummy bytes
4. Slave replies during those dummy bytes

6) Simple Arduino-Style Pseudocode

```
digitalWrite(CS, LOW);  
  
SPI.transfer(READ_CMD);           // request  
byte value = SPI.transfer(0x00); // dummy write → real read  
  
digitalWrite(CS, HIGH);
```

The first transfer sends the command (that the slave can decode).

That second transfer is the “slave → master” moment.

7) Polling Method (No Extra Wire)

Polling = master repeatedly checks if data is ready.

Time → → → →

Master:	check	check	check	read
Slave :	no	no	yes	data

8) Polling Example (Status Register)

```
byte status;  
  
do {  
    digitalWrite(CS, LOW);  
    SPI.transfer(READ_STATUS);  
    status = SPI.transfer(0x00);  
    digitalWrite(CS, HIGH);  
} while ((status & 0x01) == 0);    // wait until "data ready"
```

Then read the real data.

```
digitalWrite(CS, LOW);  
SPI.transfer(READ_DATA);  
byte data = SPI.transfer(0x00);    // clocks for reply  
digitalWrite(CS, HIGH);
```

10) Polling Pros / Cons

Polling	Result
Easy to teach	✓
No extra pin	✓
Wastes CPU time	✗
Can add delay (latency)	✗

11) Interrupt Method (One Extra Wire)

Instead of "check check check"...

Slave raises a GPIO pin:

```
Slave → INT pin → Master  
Master → SPI read (provides clock)
```

Slave still can't start SPI, but it **can notify**.

12) Interrupt Pros / Cons

Interrupt	Result
Fast response	✓
Low CPU usage	✓
Needs extra wire/pin	✗
Slightly more complex	✗

13) Summary

- The slave **cannot** start SPI transfers.
- The slave **can** send data on **MISO**.
- The master must:
 - pull **CS LOW**
 - provide **SCK clocks**
- Two common designs:
 - **Polling** (master keeps checking)
 - **Interrupt + Read** (slave signals, master reads)

Clock Speed

Let's say we need to send 320x240 RGB565 image to TFT display:

Data size: $320 \times 240 \times 2 \text{ bytes} = 153,600 \text{ bytes}$

@ 1 MHz: 1.2 seconds

@ 8 MHz: 0.15 seconds (8 times faster!)

@ 16 MHz: 0.075 seconds

Clock speed is set by the master (Arduino SPI library) and must be supported by the slave device.

- CPU 16 MHz
- Max: $F_{\text{CPU}}/2 = 8 \text{ MHz}$

Setting SPI Parameters in Arduino:

```
// 16MHz/2 = 8MHz  
SPI.setClockDivider(SPI_CLOCK_DIV2);  
SPI.setDataMode(SPI_MODE0);  
SPI.setBitOrder(MSBFIRST);
```

Default value for Arduino Nano (ATmega328P) SPI library is SPI_MODE0 + MSBFIRST.

Or using SPISettings:

```
SPI.beginTransaction(SPISettings(8000000, MSBFIRST, SPI_MODE0)); // 8 MHz
```

Examples

Example #1: Basic SPI

Simple SPI communication:

```
#include <SPI.h>

#define SS_PIN 10

void setup() {
  pinMode(SS_PIN, OUTPUT);
  digitalWrite(SS_PIN, HIGH); // Deselect slave initially

  SPI.begin(); // Initialize SPI
  SPI.setClockDivider(SPI_CLOCK_DIV8); // 2 MHz

  Serial.begin(9600);
}
```

```
void loop() {  
  // Send data to slave  
  digitalWrite(SS_PIN, LOW);    // Select slave  
  
  byte response = SPI.transfer(0xA5); // Send 0xA5, receive response  
  
  digitalWrite(SS_PIN, HIGH); // Deselect slave  
  
  Serial.print("Sent: 0xA5, Received: 0x");  
  Serial.println(response, HEX);  
  
  delay(1000);  
}
```

Output:

```
Sent: 0xA5, Received: 0x3F  
Sent: 0xA5, Received: 0x3F
```

Arduino Code Example #2: SPI Settings

Configuring SPI for different devices:

```
#include <SPI.h>

#define SD_CARD_CS    4
#define TFT_DISPLAY_CS 10
#define RF_MODULE_CS  7

void setup() {
    SPI.begin();

    pinMode(SD_CARD_CS, OUTPUT);
    pinMode(TFT_DISPLAY_CS, OUTPUT);
    pinMode(RF_MODULE_CS, OUTPUT);

    // Deselect all devices
    digitalWrite(SD_CARD_CS, HIGH);
    digitalWrite(TFT_DISPLAY_CS, HIGH);
    digitalWrite(RF_MODULE_CS, HIGH);
}
```

```

void communicateWithSDCard() {
    // SD Card: Mode 0, 4 MHz, MSB first
    SPI.beginTransaction(SPISettings(4000000, MSBFIRST, SPI_MODE0));
    digitalWrite(SD_CARD_CS, LOW);

    // ... SPI transfers ...

    digitalWrite(SD_CARD_CS, HIGH);
    SPI.endTransaction();
}

void communicateWithDisplay() {
    // TFT: Mode 0, 16 MHz, MSB first
    SPI.beginTransaction(SPISettings(16000000, MSBFIRST, SPI_MODE0));
    digitalWrite(TFT_DISPLAY_CS, LOW);

    // ... SPI transfers ...

    digitalWrite(TFT_DISPLAY_CS, HIGH);
    SPI.endTransaction();
}

void communicateWithRF() {
    // NRF24L01: Mode 0, 8 MHz, MSB first
    SPI.beginTransaction(SPISettings(8000000, MSBFIRST, SPI_MODE0));
    digitalWrite(RF_MODULE_CS, LOW);

    // ... SPI transfers ...

    digitalWrite(RF_MODULE_CS, HIGH);
    SPI.endTransaction();
}

```

Arduino Code Example #3: Reading from Device

Reading from MCP3008 ADC (8-channel 10-bit ADC):

```
#include <SPI.h>

#define ADC_CS 10

void setup() {
    pinMode(ADC_CS, OUTPUT);
    digitalWrite(ADC_CS, HIGH);

    SPI.begin();
    SPI.setClockDivider(SPI_CLOCK_DIV16); // 1 MHz
    Serial.begin(9600);
}
```



```
int readADC(byte channel) {  
    // MCP3008 protocol:  
    // Send: [start bit][single-ended][channel][don't care bits]  
  
    digitalWrite(ADC_CS, LOW);  
  
    // Start bit + single-ended mode  
    SPI.transfer(0x01);  
  
    // Channel selection (D7-D4) + get first 2 bits of result  
    byte highByte = SPI.transfer((channel << 4) & 0xF0);  
  
    // Get remaining 8 bits  
    byte lowByte = SPI.transfer(0x00);  
  
    digitalWrite(ADC_CS, HIGH);  
  
    // Combine to 10-bit result  
    int result = ((highByte & 0x03) << 8) | lowByte;  
    return result;  
}
```

```
void loop() {  
    int value = readADC(0);    // Read channel 0  
  
    float voltage = value * (5.0 / 1024.0);  
  
    Serial.print("ADC Value: ");  
    Serial.print(value);  
    Serial.print(" = ");  
    Serial.print(voltage);  
    Serial.println(" V");  
  
    delay(500);  
}
```

Arduino Code Example #4: SD Card

Reading file from SD card:

```
#include <SPI.h>
#include <SD.h>

#define SD_CS 4

void setup() {
  Serial.begin(9600);

  if (!SD.begin(SD_CS)) {
    Serial.println("SD card initialization failed!");
    return;
  }

  Serial.println("SD card initialized.");

  // Read file
  File myFile = SD.open("test.txt");
  if (myFile) {
    while (myFile.available()) {
      Serial.write(myFile.read());
    }
    myFile.close();
  } else {
```

```
void loop() {  
  // Write sensor data to SD card  
  File dataFile = SD.open("datalog.txt", FILE_WRITE);  
  
  if (dataFile) {  
    int sensorValue = analogRead(A0);  
    dataFile.print("Time: ");  
    dataFile.print(millis());  
    dataFile.print(", Value: ");  
    dataFile.println(sensorValue);  
    dataFile.close();  
  }  
  
  delay(1000);  
}
```

Arduino Code Example #5: TFT Display

Drawing on ILI9341 TFT display:

```
#include <SPI.h>
#include <Adafruit_GFX.h>
#include <Adafruit_ILI9341.h>
```

```
#define TFT_CS    10
#define TFT_DC    9
#define TFT_RST   8
```

```
Adafruit_ILI9341 tft = Adafruit_ILI9341(TFT_CS, TFT_DC, TFT_RST);
```

```
void setup() {  
  tft.begin();  
  tft.setRotation(3);  // Landscape  
  
  // Fast SPI for display  
  tft.fillScreen(ILI9341_BLACK);  
  
  // Draw text  
  tft.setTextColor(ILI9341_WHITE);  
  tft.setTextSize(3);  
  tft.setCursor(50, 100);  
  tft.println("Hello SPI!");  
  
  // Draw shapes  
  tft.fillCircle(160, 120, 40, ILI9341_RED);  
  tft.drawRect(20, 20, 100, 60, ILI9341_GREEN);  
}
```

```
void loop() {  
    // Update display with sensor data  
    int temperature = 25; // Read from sensor  
  
    tft.fillRect(10, 200, 300, 30, ILI9341_BLACK);  
    tft.setCursor(10, 200);  
    tft.print("Temp: ");  
    tft.print(temperature);  
    tft.print(" C");  
  
    delay(1000);  
}
```

Common SPI Devices & Their Uses

Storage Devices

SD/MicroSD Card

W25Q series Flash

AT25 series EEPROM

→ Data logging, audio files

→ Program storage, file system

→ Configuration storage

Displays

ILI9341 (2.4" TFT)	→ 320x240 color display
ST7735 (1.8" TFT)	→ 128x160 color display
Nokia 5110 LCD	→ 84x48 monochrome
MAX7219 LED Matrix	→ 8x8 LED displays

Sensors & ADC/DAC

MCP3008	→ 8-channel 10-bit ADC
ADS1256	→ 24-bit high-precision ADC
MCP4921	→ 12-bit DAC
BME680	→ Environment sensor (also I2C)

Communication

NRF24L01 → 2.4GHz wireless transceiver

RFM69/RFM95 (LoRa) → Long-range radio

W5500 → Ethernet controller

ESP8266 → WiFi module (also UART)